various government departments and the chief minister made it a point to attend each one of them. Modi had one message at these sammelans: 'If you have any problem, then you write a letter to me. Your brother, your son is sitting in Gandhinagar. Just send a postcard.'[3] The 2007 Gujarat campaign is now primarily remembered for Modi's return to Hindutva as the primary poll plank. It was an election in which he accused the Manmohan Singh-led UPA government in Delhi of replacing the map of India on rupee coins with a cross (the BJP called it a plan by the 'government machinery to push Christian beliefs') and alleged that Sohrabuddin was a 'hero for the Congress'. Hardline Hindutva combined with a focus on what was later to be marketed nationally as the Gujarat model of development became the BJP's primary differentiator in that campaign.[4] Yet, beneath the sharp edges of the communal–secular divide, it was the strategic wooing of the women's vote that would be the bedrock of the party's political mobilisation.

This was so crucial to the Gujarat BJP's political outreach in 2007 that a drop in male voting in the state's first polling phase in Saurashtra and South Gujarat—vis-à-vis women voting which remained as high as in 2002—caused a 'lot of excitement in the Narendra Modi camp'.[5] A Modi confidante, speaking before votes were counted, told *The Times of India* that the chief minister's strategy of reaching out to women through the district-wise mahila sammelans had 'probably helped in offsetting the Sonia factor' as well as the internal discontent and rumblings of 'Patel power'. Gujarat BJP Spokesperson Yamal Vyas summed up this view, saying, 'There is no doubt Modi is popular among women and they came out to vote because of him.'[6] The issue of Modi's mahila sammelans became so potent locally that the leader of the Opposition in the state, the Congress's Arjun Modhwadia, raised the matter in the state assembly, asking who had paid for these women-only meetings that Modi attended. The Gujarat government answered with administrative details on the floor of the assembly. It explained that a total of thirty-one such meetings were held. A sum of ₹10.8 crore had been spent on them by various boards and state corporations, including ₹9.9 lakh (0.1 per cent) by the Central